

FROM HOME FRONT TO front lines

THE GREAT WAR

In summer 1917, the Russian Army was in trouble. Beset by desertions and close to defeat, they took the extreme measure of forming several all-female battalions in an attempt to inspire their male soldiers. Around 5,000 women eagerly took up arms, with two of the battalions seeing action on the front line. The most famous was Petrograd's so-called Battalion of Death, led by a peasant woman named Maria Bochkareva.

In July 1917, in the Kerensky Offensive, Bochkareva's battalion was placed alongside a male force, and reportedly had to fend off attacks from their own countrymen. When the time came to go over the trenches, the men hesitated, but the Battalion of Death stormed out, pushing into German territory and smashing bottles of vodka they found in the Russian men's trenches. Without reinforcements, they were forced to retreat. Eventually, due to hostility from male units, the women's battalions were disbanded.

Women, including Romanian war hero Ecaterina Teodoroiu, also fought for Serbia and Romania. Initially serving as a nurse, she was allowed to join an infantry regiment but was later killed in battle during a counterattack against German troops.

The fighting women of the Eastern Front were something of an exception. During the war, the women who ventured closest to the fighting were usually nurses. When the war broke out, Dr. Elsie Inglis, a British suffragette, offered the War Office her expertise in training nurses but was told to

◀ "All for the soldiers"

Propaganda called on Russian women to work to support the war effort. However, it could not stop the women's rebellions that broke out over food shortages in Russia and elsewhere.

